

services of competent and trustworthy engineers? How would railways in India handle these problems? But the railways were eventually introduced as they were regarded as a marvel.

In 1880, Durgacharan Ray published a longish story, a bit like a travelogue, in Bengali. This was titled “Debganer Martye Agaman” (The gods come to earth). The gods, that is, Brahma, Indra, and Varuna, visit earth. More specifically, they visit Calcutta, then the capital. The purpose is to take stock of the effects of British rule in India. This involved the railways as well, as they took a train to Calcutta and were barred from entering the waiting room at the railway station, because the definition of “gentlemen” who were entitled to use the waiting room did not include the non-British, gods or otherwise. But the gods were so impressed that they resolved to replicate many of these marvels, including the railways, in heaven.

The younger generation doesn't identify with railways. With civil aviation expanding and more airports being built, combined with better roads and more comfortable cars, who travels on trains? Who identifies with trains? The ones that do are the older generation, who identify with strange objects such as steam locomotives. On rare occasions, the young may visit the National Railway Museum, or the Rewari Heritage Steam Locomotive Museum, or the other railway museums and heritage galleries or parks. There are 34 of these and three more are being developed. But those will be rare occasions. Until bullet trains and better stations start to wean people back towards train travel, even multi-modal travel, who will tell them about this heritage and legacy? Even when they are drawn back towards train travel, this will be a different kind of train travel, different from the history. Yes, there are books on the history of railways in India, several of them in fact. However, those are generally academic and unattractive, somewhat boring to read. I am delighted this present volume is being brought out, delightful in pictures and content. Across seven chapters, it takes us from the beginnings (those beginnings were in the 1830s, much before 1853) to the present and the future. As this book is being published, a series of reforms have been introduced for the Indian Railways by the government. The Indian Railways will never be the same. The future